# Understanding Data Collection Instruments

Revisiting Survey research, Self Reports, Questionnaires (Section 1)
Interviews, Key Informant Interviews, Focus Group Discussions (Section 2)

# Survey Research

A data collection method that applies a standard instrument in a systematic way to take measures from a large number of units

Useful for both qualitative and quantitative methods for researchers to collect data from populations

Useful for descriptive, explanatory, exploratory, and applied research (Optimum for studies where people are the units of analysis and are referred to as respondents or informants)

Examples of survey research used within crime analysis: National Crime Victimization Survey, Uniform Crime Report (Used to measure the extent of victimization from occurrences of crime, also to assess data on offenders, victims, and other aspects)

# Self Reports

Used widely to analyse the extent of crime occurrences

Used as a tool where informants/respondents inform of crimes they have committed (may or may not be reported to formal law enforcement agencies)

Emphasis is usually placed on frequency of crime offended, and prevalence

Example: 1982 study by Jan and Marcia Chaiken (Varieties of Criminal Behaviour)

# Surveys seen within Criminology based studies

Perceptions and Attitude measurement Surveys (Widely used to assess the opinions of respondents/informants on research enquiries)

Victim Surveys (Targeted): Specifies on the selected group of victims of interest by the researchers

General purpose crime surveys: Seen within national implementation for statistics on crime occurrences

Example: British Crime Survey (BCS) collects data on fear of crime (1984), contacts with the police (1988, 1996, 2000), self-reported drug use (1994), security measures used to protect households and vehicles (1996), and fraud and technology crimes (2002–2003).

# Questionnaires

By literal meaning, refers to a ‘collection of questions’

Used both for qualitative and quantitative research enquiries

Suggested characteristics: Clarity, Short items (questions/statements), Avoidance of negative items (use of ‘not’ in questionnaire statements), Avoidance of biased items and terms that may result in leading questions

# General Questionnaire formats

Uncluttered questions and statements to allow for reading space, convenience and preventing misinterpretation

Use of contingency questions to avoid double barrelled questions

Use of matrix questions to ask a number of questions which have the same answer categories (useful for space use, convenience)

Sequences based on general to specific, avoiding bias questions

# Self administered questionnaires

Mail surveys (still widely used) prove convenient, easy to distribute (Use of cover letters with (1) some institution that the respondent respects or can identify with or (2) a neutral but impressive-sounding affiliation

Emphasis placed on response rate

Computer Based Self Administration surveys (cheaper, more accessibility)